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The Divine Right of the King

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The Divine Right of the King

*Kings take pleasure in honest lips; they value a man who speaks the truth.
(Proverbs 16:13)*

*He who loves a pure heart and whose speech is gracious will have the king for
his friend. (Proverbs 22:11)*

*Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will serve before kings; he will not
serve before obscure men. (Proverbs 22:29)*

*Do not exalt yourself in the king's presence, and do not claim a place among
great men; it is better for him to say to you, "Come up here," than for him to
humiliate you before a nobleman. (Proverbs 25:6-7)*

For all their benefits, democracies cheat their citizens of a number of valuable life lessons. One is learning to relate to absolute authority. Human nature—bent as it is toward rebellion—is taught submission only through the discipline of dealing with authority against which there is no appeal. When a king speaks, it is a final answer. When a president speaks, it may well be subject to appeal, veto, or negotiability. It is that perception of negotiability that gives a foot in the door for man's rebellion...and its consequences.

When I was in college ROTC, I was taught a very alien and often-despised concept called "military authority." Bringing my democratic presuppositions and youthful arrogance to the military environment cost me many hours of labor working off "demerits" administered because of my lack of submission to the officers over me. I was told the only acceptable answers were, "Yes, sir," "No, sir," and "No excuse, sir." Awful...but wonderful. I learned my heart of rebellion and ways to respond to nonnegotiable authority. The military chain of command taught me how to respond to God.

Proverbs teaches principles for relating successfully to those in authority—husbands, bosses, police, governors, and God. Following them is a key to better relationships, even if their authority is not "absolute."

Watchman Nee, in his book *Spiritual Authority*, teaches that in every situation a believer is to be keenly aware of two dynamics—the presence of sin and the presence of authority. He also taught that the righteous person “keeps his peace and keeps his place.”

Principle: Asking yourself, “Is there sin here?” and “Who’s in authority here?” will quickly reveal the moral compass for a situation—avoid the sin and submit to the authority.

There is a pecking order even among high-level authorities. The general can overrule the captain and the captain the sergeant. In like manner, in the heavenly chain of authority, there is one authority that transcends all others. He is called the “King of all kings.”

Principle: If you are tempted to play loosely with the authority over you, be most keenly aware that there is One whose authority is never to be tested. To do so is a matter of spiritual life and death! He isn’t called King of Kings for nothing.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]